

Instructional Validation & Iteration Log

From Storyboard to Storyline: Key Decisions & Rationale

FinTech & Startups Learning Experience — Storyline Portfolio Project

This log documents where the built Storyline simulation diverged from the original Instructional

Storyboard, and why. Instructional design rarely survives first contact with a build tool unchanged —

what matters is whether each divergence was a deliberate, defensible trade-off or an accidental drift.

Every change below was made consciously, with its instructional consequences weighed before being accepted.

1. Scope: Reducing 8 teams to 3

Original storyboard: 8 teams/tables, matching the full live event (Healthcare, Real Estate,

Agriculture, Education, and four additional sectors).

Built simulation: 3 teams/tables (Healthcare, Agriculture, Education).

Rationale: As a portfolio piece rather than a live delivery, the goal was to demonstrate every core

mechanic clearly, not exhaustively replicate every instance of it. Three tables preserve genuine sector diversity and three distinct fintech mechanisms (insurance, credit-scoring, tuition-financing) while cutting build time roughly in half. Real Estate was dropped last, once it became clear a fourth full pitch script and recording added build cost without adding anything a reviewer would learn from a fourth example.

What this demonstrates: Recognizing when full-scale fidelity serves the audience and when it's just

additional labor — a portfolio deliverable and a client deliverable have different

definitions of
"complete."

2. Team Building: from interactive → static → interactive again

Original storyboard: Learner actively drags startup ideas and team members onto tables
(a "team assigner" mechanic).

First revision: Interaction removed entirely — a static image of 3 pre-formed tables with pre-assigned ideas, since the original mechanic didn't survive scope reduction cleanly and added disproportionate build complexity for 3 tables.

Final version: Interaction restored, but reframed — three short persona-authored comments (one Reality Checker comment on Healthcare, one Architect comment on Agriculture, one Visionary comment on Education) that the learner drags onto the correct table.

Rationale: Removing the interaction solved a build problem but created an instructional one — this screen went from doing real cognitive work (Gagné's Elicit Performance, Kolb's Active Experimentation) to doing none. Rather than accept that trade-off permanently, the mechanic was redesigned around a task that was actually easy to build at small scale: content-recognition rather than team-formation. The result does different instructional work than originally planned (Bloom's Apply/Analyze via topic-matching, rather than the original team-logistics task) but restores genuine learner action to the screen.

What this demonstrates: A willingness to abandon a mechanic that wasn't working rather than force it, and — more importantly — the reflex to notice when a "fix" (removing the

interaction) quietly created a new problem (a passive screen), and to solve that in turn rather than let it stand.

3. The Elevator Pitch: from single winner to genuine learner evaluation

Original storyboard: Sharks decide the winner; learner observes the outcome.

Built simulation: Sharks have already decided, but the learner is shown judging criteria and asked to cast their own pick via a drag-the-trophy mechanic, before receiving a response confirming a match or explaining the experts' reasoning if their pick differs.

Rationale: Passive observation of an expert decision teaches nothing the learner can practice. Adding learner choice without real criteria would have been arbitrary preference-clicking, not evaluation. The final design preserves the credibility of expert judgment (the decision isn't overridden) while giving the learner a genuine evaluative task anchored to stated criteria — pushing the activity from passive observation up to Bloom's "Evaluate" level.

What this demonstrates: Distinguishing genuine interactivity from interactivity for its own sake — the redesign was driven by asking what specific thinking skill the learner should practice, not by adding a mechanic because it seemed more engaging.

4. Persona-differentiated pitch delivery: considered and deliberately excluded

Considered: Having the pitch's content or framing shift depending on which team member (persona) the learner chose to "step up" and deliver it.

Decision: Excluded. Pitch content stays uniform regardless of who delivers it.

Rationale: The evaluative focus of this activity is the idea's merit, not the messenger's communication style. Differentiating delivery by persona would have introduced a variable unrelated to what the learner is actually meant to judge, muddying the evaluation task rather than sharpening it.

What this demonstrates: Not every "more differentiated" option is a better one — sometimes the right design choice is deliberate uniformity, and naming that decision (rather than silently defaulting to the simpler option) keeps the reasoning visible.

5. The World Café: adding a concept-explanation beat

Original storyboard: The host explains the rules of the World Café directly.

Built simulation: The host first explains what a "World Café" actually is — a short, casual bridge line — before moving into the rules.

Rationale: A term like "World Café" carries no inherent meaning to a first-time learner; skipping straight to rules assumes context that was never given. This closes a small but real comprehension gap identified while building the screen, following the same principle that prompted adding an explicit "objectives" moment (Gagné's Event 2) earlier in the project.

What this demonstrates: Catching an unstated assumption before a reviewer does — a habit carried consistently across this whole project, not a one-off fix.

6. Merging screens for continuity

Changes: The Elevator Pitch, Shark Tank, and Reward were merged into a single continuous action-outcome flow. The World Café Introduction and Ambassador Role Assignment were merged. The Briefing Stage and Homecoming were merged.

Rationale: In each case, the original two activities were never truly independent — they were one continuous cause-and-effect sequence (pitch leads to judgment leads to reward; explanation leads directly to role assignment; leaving a team leads directly to returning to it). Keeping them as separate rows in the storyboard added documentation overhead without adding clarity.

What this demonstrates: Recognizing the difference between activities that are truly distinct and activities that only look distinct on paper — merging these tightened both the build and the documentation without losing any instructional nuance.

7. Persona voice: sharpening the arrival thought bubbles

First draft: Three arrival thought bubbles that were structurally similar to one another ("wondering whether...", "not sure how...", "wondering whether...").

Revised version: Three bubbles rebuilt around distinct emotional registers — self-consciousness for the Aspiring Entrepreneur, skepticism for the Tech Enthusiast, and low-stakes uncertainty for the Curious Individual — matching the affective arcs established in the Learner Journey Map.

Rationale: The first draft technically satisfied the "persona-specific" requirement but flattened the actual psychological differences between personas that had been carefully built earlier in the project. A quick self-audit against the original Journey Map surfaced the gap before it reached the final build.

What this demonstrates: Consistency-checking a new artifact against earlier, more foundational ones (the Journey Map) rather than treating each screen as an isolated writing task.

8. The Notebook: excluded from interaction, partially preserved symbolically

Storyboard decision: The physical notebook was excluded entirely — no digital equivalent, since a text-entry field couldn't replicate its physicality or continuity across the live event.

Built simulation: While no interactive notebook exists, physical notebook props appear visually in the Closing Ritual scene, held up alongside trophies/badges.

Rationale: This wasn't a reversal of the original exclusion decision — the notebook still isn't a functional, interactive element anywhere in the build. But its symbolic presence in the closing image preserves a visual callback to something that mattered in the live event, without pretending a digital field could do the same job.

What this demonstrates: An excluded element can still be honored visually without contradicting the original rationale for excluding it functionally — these are two different questions, and worth treating as such.

Summary

Across this build, three patterns recur: **cutting scope without cutting instructional intent** (3 teams instead of 8, still testing the same mechanics), **catching problems created by earlier fixes** (removing then restoring interactivity at Screen 2.2), and **checking new work against earlier, more foundational artifacts** (the Journey Map, the modified Kirkpatrick model, Gagné's framework) rather than treating each screen as a standalone task. Together, these reflect a design process that stayed accountable to its own reasoning throughout, even as the practical realities of building in Storyline required real, sometimes repeated, adjustment.